



Honduras

Straddling the Central American isthmus, Honduras returned to democratic rule in 1984, after a period of military government. Hurricane Mitch devastated the country in 1998.



GEOGRAPHY

Narrow plains along both coasts, with a mountainous interior, cut by river valleys. Tropical forests, swamps, and lagoons in the east.



CLIMATE

Tropical coastal lowlands are hot and humid, with May–October rains. Interior is cooler and drier.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The majority of the population is *mestizo* (mixed race). An English-speaking *garifuna* (black) community and Miskito Amerindians struggle to preserve their rights to land along the remote Caribbean coast. Women's status remains low. Hurricane Mitch impoverished 85% of the population. Wealth inequalities are large and poverty is at the root of social tension. The army ousted the president in 2009. Violent crime is a major issue.



THE ECONOMY

Garments, coffee, bananas, and shellfish are exported. Remittances account for a fifth of GDP. Debt relief from 2005. Mineral potential. High underemployment and corruption.



INSIGHT: *The Honduran currency is named after a Lenca Indian chief who was the main leader of resistance to the Spanish conquest in the 16th century*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Honduras

DATE OF FORMATION: 1838

CAPITAL: Tegucigalpa

POPULATION: 7.47 million

TOTAL AREA: 43,278 sq. miles
(112,090 sq. km)

DENSITY: 173 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Spanish*, Garifuna, English Creole

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 97%, Protestant 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Mestizo 90%, Black African 5%, Amerindian 4%, White 1%

GOVERNMENT: Transitional regime

CURRENCY: Lempira = 100 centavos